



Killer cones

Most sea snails are slow-moving animals and are also ponderous feeders. Cone snails overcome these physical disadvantages by paralyzing their prey with toxic venom. They impale passing fish and other animals with their harpoonlike mouthparts and inject them with poison. This cone snail has caught a blenny and is using its foot to haul in its meal.



Lethal skin

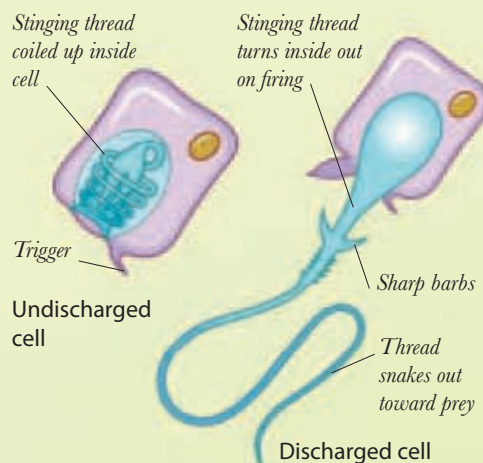
In the forests of Central and South America, poison dart frogs use brilliant colors to warn predators that they are highly dangerous. All of them have poisonous skins, and some kinds produce batrachotoxin, which is the most powerful poison in the animal world. In the Amazon, human forest-dwellers traditionally use the poison when hunting. Just 0.000035 oz (1 mg) of the poison, smeared on the tip of a blowpipe dart, is more than enough to kill a monkey or sloth.

Paralyzing poison

After stinging a spider, a female spider-hunting wasp drags its prey away to its burrow. The spider is not dead, but is paralyzed by the wasp's venom, which prevents it from fighting back. Once in the burrow, the wasp will lay an egg on the spider. In the days that follow, the egg will hatch, and the wasp grub will feed on its living food supply.

Stinging cells

Jellyfish and their relatives have trailing tentacles armed with batteries of stinging cells, called cnidocytes. There is a poison-tipped thread coiled up inside each cell and a trigger hair on the outside. When prey touches the trigger, the stinging thread explodes outward and impales the victim. After firing, the cnidocyte is replaced by a new cell.



Deadly trail

The Portuguese man-of-war has a gas-filled float, trailing tentacles up to 20 ft (6 m) long. Each tentacle is covered with thousands of cnidocytes, which fire if they make contact with prey. The tentacles then contract to haul in the food.

Foldaway fangs

A snake's fangs are specialized teeth that inject venom into its prey. Many snakes have fixed fangs, but those of rattlesnakes and their relatives are hinged and swing forward as they bite. Snake venom works in different ways. Some kinds act on the prey's nervous system, stopping the heart and lungs from working and paralyzing muscles.

Rattlesnake venom cuts off its victim's circulation by clotting the blood. Snake venom is not always injected—spitting cobras defend themselves by firing it through the air and into their attacker's eyes.

